

Accessibility review: National History Museum

****Observer:**** Mia Tursman

****Date:**** 2026-05-11

****Overall compliance:**** 63% of rated items met (10 met, 3 not met, 3 partial, 1 N/A)

Exhibits & objects

- ☐ Small objects mounted at or below 40 in. (seated eye level) — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Display cases shallow enough to see objects from above — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Objects have 70% color contrast against their background — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Touchable objects or reproductions available for tactile access — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Audio description provided for items that cannot be touched — *(not rated)*
- ☐ No objects protrude more than 4 in. from walls at head height — *(not rated)*
- ☐ No low floor-level objects that could be tripping hazards — *(not rated)*
- ☐ At least 100 lux of light on displayed objects — *(not rated)*

Labels & text

- ☒ Labels use plain English — short sentences, active voice — ****Met****
- ☒ Legible font used — no all-caps or decorative scripts — ****Met****
- ☐  Type size appropriate for the viewing distance — ****Partial****
 - > Many historical story captions were an appropriate size, however oftentimes image labels were much smaller and harder to read
- ☒ High contrast between label text and background (70%) — ****Met****
- ☐  Labels printed on matte, non-glare surfaces — ****Partial****
 - > Some labels were placed behind glass and they had a shadow on the texts as well
- ☒ Wall labels centered at approx. 54 in. (readable seated & standing) — ****Met****
- ☒  Label positions consistent throughout the exhibition — ****Not met****
 - > Some labels in display cases were tilted forward so they could be read from any angle, however some were flat down, facing upward which would be difficult for a user in a wheelchair to read. There is no reason why they could not all be tilted slightly forward
- ☒  Alternative formats available: Braille, large print, or audio guide — ****Not met****
 - > One small activity had a braille option telling you where to throw your paper away, but it was not present anywhere else in the museum. The audio guide seemed to only be for certain artifacts that did not have written descriptors, but not for general information about the museum or the history. It also would have been impossible to tell which number on the audio guide should be pressed if you could not see it written behind the glass
- ☐  100–300 lux of light on all label surfaces — ****Partial****
 - > Certain rooms were dimly lit to help preserve the artifacts, and the Egypt room was almost impossible to read on many surfaces. Other than that it was good everywhere else.

Audio/visual & interactives

- ☐ All videos and audio programs are captioned or have printed scripts — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Silent audiovisuals labelled to confirm no audio is being missed — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Audio description available for image-based content — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Interactive controls reachable from a wheelchair (max. 48 in. height) — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Controls usable one-handed — no tight grip or twisting required — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Touch targets at least 3 in. in diameter — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Instructions provided in both print and audio formats — *(not rated)*
- ☐ No furniture or objects blocking access to interactives — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Assistive listening system available in programming spaces — *(not rated)*

Pathways & navigation

- ☐ Main circulation route at least 36 in. wide (60 in. preferred) — *(not rated)*
- ☐ At least 80 in. of clear overhead clearance throughout — *(not rated)*
- ☒ Route is step-free, or ramps/lifts provided at level changes — **Not met**
> There was no elevator to the second floor!!!
- ☐ Floor surface is stable, firm, and slip-resistant — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Route well lit (50–100 lux) with no confusing shadow pools — *(not rated)*
- ☐ 70% color contrast between floor and walls/furniture — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Accessible floor map available at the gallery entrance — *(not rated)*
- ☐ More than one exit from the exhibition — *(not rated)*
- ☐ 60 in. wheelchair turning space at any dead ends — *(not rated)*

Seating & furniture

- ☒ Seating provided in every gallery (or immediately adjacent) — **Met**
- ☐ At least 50% of seats are accessible — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Seats have both back and arm support; seat height 17–19 in. — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Space for wheelchair users beside fixed seating — *(not rated)*
- ☐ Seats clearly visible — contrast with floors and walls — *(not rated)*
- ☒ Seats do not block pathways or interactive controls — **Met**
- ☐ Display cases have cane-detectable lower edges (at or below 27 in.) — *(not rated)*

Safety & content

- ☒ Both visual and audible fire alarms are present — **Met**
- ☒ Accessible emergency exits clearly marked with access symbols — **Met**
- ☒ Exhibition addresses multiple intellectual levels and sensory channels — **Met**
- ☒ People with disabilities represented respectfully in exhibit content — **Met**
- ☐ Labels use person-first language throughout — **N/A**
> I am confused by what this means

Checklist based on the [Smithsonian Guidelines for Accessible Exhibition Design](<https://www.sifacilities.si.edu/sites/default/files/Files/Accessibility/accessible-exhibition-design1.pdf>)